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Microsoft open sources 60,000 patents

Erich Andersen, Microsoft's corporate VP and deputy general counsel, announced that the software giant has joined the Open Invention Network (OIN), a community dedicated to protecting Linux and other open source software programs from patent risks. Microsoft has made 60,000 of its patents open source to help Linux.

"We know Microsoft's decision to join OIN may be viewed as surprising to some; it is no secret that there has been friction in the past between Microsoft and the open source community over the issue of patents," Andersen wrote. "For others who have followed our evolution, we hope this announcement will be viewed as the next logical step for a company that is listening to customers and developers, and is firmly committed to Linux and other open source programs," he added.

Since its founding in 2005, OIN has been at the forefront of helping companies manage patent risks. In the years before the founding of OIN, many open source licences explicitly covered only copyright interests and were silent about patents. OIN was designed to address this concern by creating a voluntary system of patent cross-licences between member companies covering Linux system technologies. OIN has also been active in acquiring patents, at times, to help defend the community and to provide education and advice about the intersection of open source and intellectual property.

OIN provides a licence platform for roughly 2,650 companies globally. The licensees range from individual developers and startups to some of the biggest technology companies and patent holders on the planet.

Anderson also mentioned in the announcement that, "Joining OIN reflects Microsoft's patent practice evolving in lock-step with the company's views on Linux and open source, more generally. We began this journey over two years ago through programs like Azure IP Advantage, which extended Microsoft's indemnification pledge to open source software powering Azure services. We doubled down on this new approach when we stood with Red Hat and others to apply GPL v.3 'cure' principles to GPLv.2 code, and when we recently joined the LOT Network, an organisation dedicated to addressing patent abuse by companies in the business of assertion."

Microsoft's Infer.NET machine learning framework goes open source

Microsoft has announced that one of its top-tier cross-platform frameworks for model based machine learning is now open to all, worldwide.

"We're extremely excited today to open source Infer.NET on GitHub under the permissive MIT licence for free use in commercial applications," Yordan Zaykov, principal research software engineering lead at Microsoft, said in an official statement.

The research team of Microsoft at Cambridge began the journey of developing the framework back in 2004. Infer.NET initially was proposed as a research tool, and in 2008 it was released for academic use. But gradually over time, the framework evolved from a research tool to a machine learning engine in a number of Microsoft products —in Office, Xbox and Azure.

The official statement by Microsoft said: "Infer.NET enables a model based approach to machine learning. This lets you incorporate domain knowledge into your model. The framework can then build a bespoke machine learning algorithm directly from that model. This means that instead of having to map your problem onto a pre-existing learning algorithm that you've been given, Infer.NET actually constructs a learning algorithm for you, based on the model you've provided."

Infer.NET can come into use if you have extensive knowledge about the domain you are working in, if knowing the system's behaviour is important to you, or if you have a production system that should be informed about the arrival of new data.

The Microsoft team is looking forward to engaging with the open source community in enhancing and developing the framework further. Infer.NET will soon become part of ML.NET – Microsoft's machine learning framework. Some steps have already been taken by the Microsoft team to integrate Infer.NET with ML.NET.